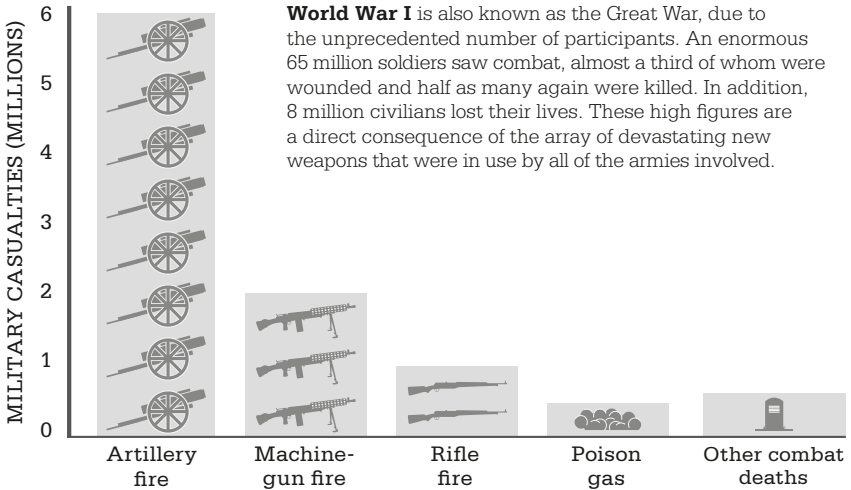




World War I is also known as the Great War, due to the unprecedented number of participants. An enormous 65 million soldiers saw combat, almost a third of whom were wounded and half as many again were killed. In addition, 8 million civilians lost their lives. These high figures are a direct consequence of the array of devastating new weapons that were in use by all of the armies involved.

Global conflict

The key belligerent states brought their vast empires into war with them, and the conflict soon became a world war. German colonies in China and the Pacific were invaded by Japan, which entered the war on the side of the Allies. Germany's colonies in Africa were overrun by British, French, and South African troops. In May 1915, Italy joined the Allies, fighting Austria-Hungary and Germany in the Alps.

In early November 1914, the Ottoman Empire, an Islamic power, abandoned its neutrality and declared a military *jihad* (holy war) against France, Russia, and Britain. The US was drawn into the war by German submarine attacks on commercial ships at sea, such as the one on British liner *Lusitania* in 1915, with 128 Americans on board. After a German plot to persuade Mexico into an anti-US alliance was discovered, Congress declared war in April 1917.

When the Bolsheviks in Russia negotiated a peace treaty with Germany at Brest-Litovsk on December 22, 1917, it seemed Germany had won a significant victory. They also made gains on the Western Front in 1918, but then, in July and August, the Allies counterattacked, beginning an advance that would continue until November. Four million fresh US troops helped defeat the Central Powers and bring the Germans to the peace table.

When the conflict ended, at 11 am on November 11, 1918, the alliance led by France and Britain emerged victorious. More than 65 million troops had been involved in the war, of which at least half were killed or injured. The Russian, Austrian, and German empires had collapsed. After the war, the Treaty of Versailles redrew the map of Europe, leaving nations, particularly Germany, embittered. A public assembly of countries, the League of Nations, was founded to help maintain peace. However, the League proved toothless in the face of countries that chose to ignore it. When fascist Benito Mussolini came to power in Italy in 1922, he denounced the Treaty. In Germany, where the response to the Treaty was one of deep resentment, the Nazi Party began to gain momentum. Far from being "the war to end all wars," World War I had instead sown the seeds of future conflict. ■



One of the social changes brought on by World War I concerned the role of women. The female population joined the war effort by working in places like munitions factories.